

VOCABULARY · CULTURE · ACTIVITIES

CHRISTMAS

La Navidad

Christmas in Spain 🇪🇸 and Argentina 🇦🇷: the words, the food, the songs and the night the Three Kings arrive

PONCHO
SPANISH

¡FELIZ NAVIDAD!

In December half the Spanish-speaking world wraps up warm and the other half goes to the beach, and both halves eat far too much, sing the same songs and stay up far too late.

This resource collects more than 80 Christmas words and expressions, each one in a real sentence: the decorations, the big dinner on Christmas Eve, the sweets, the carols, the Three Kings and the twelve grapes at midnight on New Year's Eve.

Spanish Christmas is not a copy of the British one. The main meal is on the night of the 24th, lots of children get their presents on 6 January, and in Argentina and Chile it is the middle of summer. At the end you'll find activities and all the answers.

How to use it

1. **Read the word, then the sentence.** Words stick better when you see them in action.
2. **Say it out loud.** Nochebuena and villancico are lovely to pronounce.
3. **Compare it with your Christmas.** What's the same? What's completely different?
4. **Try the activities** without looking back, then check the answers.

Three nights, three names

Spanish has a different word for each big night. **La Nochebuena** is Christmas Eve, 24 December. **La Navidad** is Christmas Day, 25 December. **La Nochevieja** is New Year's Eve, 31 December.

la Nochebuena = 24 de diciembre

Two countries, two words

When you see two options, the first is common in Spain 🇪🇸 and the second in Argentina 🇦🇷. And remember: in Argentina, Chile and Uruguay, Christmas is in the middle of summer.

el belén 🇪🇸 = el pesebre 🇦🇷

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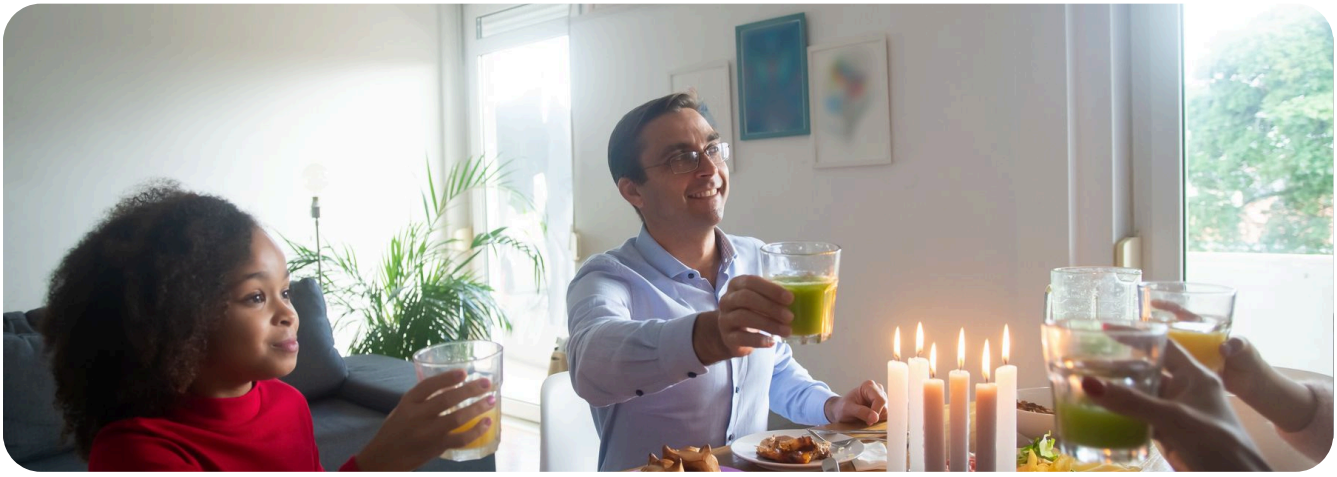
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01

LA NAVIDAD EN CASA

DECORATING THE HOUSE

Lights, a tree and a little stable on the sideboard.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la Navidad	Christmas	*La Navidad empieza a principios de diciembre.* Christmas starts at the beginning of December.
diciembre	December	*En diciembre la casa huele distinto.* In December the house smells different.
el árbol de Navidad	the Christmas tree	*Ponemos el árbol de Navidad el primer domingo.* We put the tree up on the first Sunday.
el adorno	the decoration	*Cada adorno tiene una historia.* Every decoration has a story.
la bola	the bauble	*Se me ha caído una bola roja.* I've dropped a red bauble.
las luces	the lights	*Las luces se encienden al anochecer.* The lights come on at dusk.
el belén 🇪🇸 el pesebre 🇦🇷	the nativity scene	*Mi abuela monta el belén en el salón.* My grandmother sets up the nativity scene in the living room.
la estrella	the star	*La estrella va arriba del todo.* The star goes right at the top.
la guirnalda	the garland, the tinsel	*Colgamos una guirnalda en la puerta.* We hang a garland on the door.
el calcetín 🇪🇸 la media 🇦🇷	the stocking	*Dejamos un calcetín en la chimenea.* We leave a stocking by the fireplace.
la vela	the candle	*Encendemos velas en la mesa.* We light candles on the table.

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01 · LA NAVIDAD EN CASA DECORATING THE HOUSE

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
decorar	to decorate	*Decoramos la casa entre todos.* We decorate the house together.
la tarjeta	the card	*Escribo tarjetas para mis primos.* I write cards for my cousins.
el invierno / el verano	winter / summer	*En Argentina la Navidad es en verano.* In Argentina Christmas is in summer.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

In Catalonia, in the north-east of Spain, children look after a little log with a painted face called the Tió de Nadal. They feed it for weeks, cover it with a blanket, and on Christmas Eve they tap it with sticks and sing until it 'gives' them their sweets.

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02

LA NOCHEBUENA

CHRISTMAS EVE DINNER

The biggest meal of the year, and it starts late.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la Nochebuena	Christmas Eve	*La Nochebuena es el 24 de diciembre.* Christmas Eve is 24 December.
la cena	the dinner	*La cena empieza a las diez de la noche.* Dinner starts at ten at night.
la familia	the family	*Se junta toda la familia.* The whole family gets together.
los primos	the cousins	*Mis primos llegan desde Sevilla.* My cousins arrive from Seville.
poner la mesa	to lay the table	*Me toca poner la mesa.* It's my turn to lay the table.
el mantel	the tablecloth	*Sacamos el mantel bueno.* We get out the good tablecloth.
el brindis	the toast	*Hacemos un brindis a medianoche.* We make a toast at midnight.
¡Salud!	Cheers!	*Levantamos la copa y decimos: ¡Salud!* We raise our glasses and say: Cheers!
la gamba 🇪🇸 el camarón 🇦🇷	the prawn	*Siempre hay gambas de primero.* There are always prawns to start.
el cordero	the lamb	*Mi tío prepara cordero al horno.* My uncle makes roast lamb.
el asado	the barbecue	*En Buenos Aires hacemos asado.* In Buenos Aires we have a barbecue.

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02 · LA NOCHEBUENA CHRISTMAS EVE DINNER

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la ensalada	the salad	*Con el calor, la ensalada se agradece.* In the heat, salad is very welcome.
el postre	the pudding, the dessert	*El postre llega a la una de la mañana.* Pudding arrives at one in the morning.
la sobremesa	the chat after a meal	*La sobremesa dura horas.* The chat after the meal goes on for hours.

¿Sabías que...?

In Spain the main Christmas meal is the dinner on the night of the 24th, not lunch on the 25th, and it often finishes after midnight. In Argentina, where it is summer, many families eat outside and let off fireworks as the clock strikes twelve.

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03

LOS DULCES DE NAVIDAD

CHRISTMAS SWEETS

Almonds, nougat, chocolate and a cake with a surprise inside.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el dulce	the sweet thing	*En Navidad los dulces están en todas partes.* At Christmas sweet things are everywhere.
el turrón	nougat	*El turrón duro lleva almendras enteras.* Hard nougat has whole almonds in it.
el mazapán	marzipan	*El mazapán se hace con almendra y azúcar.* Marzipan is made with almonds and sugar.
el polvorón	the crumbly shortbread	*Hay que comer el polvorón de un bocado.* You have to eat a polvorón in one bite.
el roscón de Reyes	the Three Kings ring cake	*El roscón de Reyes lleva fruta encima.* The Three Kings cake has fruit on top.
la sorpresa	the surprise	*Dentro del roscón hay una sorpresa.* There's a surprise inside the cake.
el haba	the broad bean	*A quien le toca el haba, paga el roscón.* Whoever gets the bean pays for the cake.
el pan dulce	the Christmas sweet bread	*En Argentina se come pan dulce.* In Argentina people eat pan dulce.
el chocolate caliente	hot chocolate	*Mojamos los churros en chocolate.* We dip the churros in chocolate.
el churro	the churro	*Los churros se comen de madrugada.* Churros are eaten in the early hours.
la almendra	the almond	*Las almendras llegan de Alicante.* The almonds come from Alicante.

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03 · LOS DULCES DE NAVIDAD CHRISTMAS SWEETS

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la tarta 🇪🇸 la torta 🇦🇷	the cake	*Mi madre hace una tarta enorme.* My mum makes an enormous cake.
las chucherías 🇪🇸 las golosinas 🇦🇷	the sweets	*Los niños esconden las golosinas.* The children hide the sweets.
probar	to taste, to try	*¿Quieres probar un poco?* Would you like to try a bit?

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Inside a roscón de Reyes there are two things hidden: a little figure and a dry broad bean. Whoever finds the figure is crowned king or queen for the day, and whoever bites the bean has to pay for next year's cake.

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04

LOS REGALOS Y LOS REYES MAGOS

PRESENTS AND THE THREE KINGS

In much of the Spanish-speaking world the big morning is 6 January.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el regalo	the present	*Abrimos los regalos por la mañana.* We open the presents in the morning.
los Reyes Magos	the Three Kings	*Los Reyes Magos llegan el 6 de enero.* The Three Kings arrive on 6 January.
Melchor, Gaspar y Baltasar	Melchior, Caspar and Balthazar	*Mi preferido es Baltasar.* My favourite is Balthazar.
el camello	the camel	*Dejamos agua para los camellos.* We leave water out for the camels.
Papá Noel	Father Christmas	*Papá Noel viene la noche del 24.* Father Christmas comes on the night of the 24th.
la carta	the letter	*Escribo mi carta a los Reyes en diciembre.* I write my letter to the Kings in December.
pedir	to ask for	*Este año pido una bici.* This year I'm asking for a bike.
la cabalgata	the parade	*La cabalgata pasa por el centro.* The parade goes through the town centre.
el caramelo	the sweet	*Tiran caramelos desde las carrozas.* They throw sweets from the floats.
la carroza	the float	*La carroza va llena de luces.* The float is covered in lights.
el carbón	the coal	*Si te portas mal, te traen carbón.* If you misbehave, they bring you coal.

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04 · LOS REGALOS Y LOS REYES MAGOS

PRESENTS AND THE THREE KINGS

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
envolver	to wrap	*Envolvemos los regalos con papel brillante.* We wrap the presents in shiny paper.
el papel de regalo	the wrapping paper	*El papel de regalo se rompe enseguida.* The wrapping paper tears straight away.
abrir	to open	*¡No abras nada antes de tiempo!* Don't open anything early!

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

The 'coal' naughty children get in Spain is not real coal: it is carbón dulce, a hard black sweet made of sugar. Most children get a little piece anyway, as a joke, next to their real presents.

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05

VILLANCICOS Y MÚSICA

CAROLS AND MUSIC

Spanish carols come with tambourines, and everybody sings badly on purpose.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el villancico	the Christmas carol	*Cantamos villancicos después de cenar.* We sing carols after dinner.
cantar	to sing	*Todos cantan, nadie afina.* Everyone sings, nobody is in tune.
la canción	the song	*Esa canción la cantaba mi abuelo.* My grandfather used to sing that song.
la pandereta	the tambourine	*Mi hermano toca la pandereta fatal.* My brother plays the tambourine terribly.
la zambomba	the friction drum	*La zambomba hace un ruido muy gracioso.* The zambomba makes a very funny noise.
el coro	the choir	*El coro del colegio canta en la plaza.* The school choir sings in the square.
la guitarra	the guitar	*Mi prima saca la guitarra.* My cousin gets the guitar out.
la campana	the bell	*Las campanas suenan a medianoche.* The bells ring at midnight.
el ruido	the noise	*¡Qué ruido hay en esta casa!* What a racket there is in this house!
la letra	the lyrics	*Nadie se sabe la letra entera.* Nobody knows all the words.
bailar	to dance	*Al final bailamos en el salón.* In the end we dance in the living room.

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05 · VILLANCICOS Y MÚSICA CAROLS AND MUSIC

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la misa del gallo	midnight mass	*Algunos van a la misa del gallo.* Some people go to midnight mass.
la alegría	the joy	*La casa se llena de alegría.* The house fills up with joy.
reír	to laugh	*Nos reímos hasta las tantas.* We laugh until the early hours.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Midnight mass is called la misa del gallo, 'the rooster's mass'. The story says that a cockerel crowed at midnight on the night Jesus was born, and it is the only time of year a rooster is said to crow in the dark.

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06

FIN DE AÑO

NEW YEAR

Twelve grapes, twelve chimes and a week of leftovers.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la Nochevieja	New Year's Eve	*La Nochevieja es el 31 de diciembre.* New Year's Eve is 31 December.
el Año Nuevo	New Year	*¡Feliz Año Nuevo!* Happy New Year!
las doce uvas	the twelve grapes	*Comemos doce uvas a medianoche.* We eat twelve grapes at midnight.
la campanada	the chime	*Una uva por cada campanada.* One grape for each chime.
el reloj	the clock	*Todos miran el reloj en la tele.* Everyone watches the clock on TV.
medianoche	midnight	*A medianoche nos abrazamos.* At midnight we all hug.
el abrazo	the hug	*Un abrazo para cada uno.* A hug for everybody.
los fuegos artificiales	the fireworks	*Los fuegos artificiales duran diez minutos.* The fireworks last ten minutes.
el deseo	the wish	*Pido un deseo para el año que viene.* I make a wish for next year.
el propósito	the resolution	*Mi propósito es leer más.* My resolution is to read more.
la suerte	luck	*Dicen que da suerte.* They say it brings good luck.

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06 · FIN DE AÑO NEW YEAR

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la fiesta	the party	*La fiesta sigue hasta el amanecer.* The party goes on until dawn.
las sobras	the leftovers	*Comemos sobras durante una semana.* We eat leftovers for a week.
el año que viene	next year	*El año que viene lo hacemos otra vez.* Next year we'll do it all again.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

The twelve grapes are eaten one per chime of the clock at midnight on 31 December, and it is much harder than it sounds. The custom started in Spain more than a hundred years ago and spread to Mexico, Argentina, Peru and beyond.

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07

FRASES DE NAVIDAD

CHRISTMAS PHRASES

Short sentences you could really say in December. When there are two versions, the second is how you'd say it in Argentina.

¡Feliz Navidad!
Happy Christmas!

¡Feliz Año Nuevo!
Happy New Year!

¡Felices fiestas!
Season's greetings!

¿Qué haces en Nochebuena?
What are you doing on Christmas Eve?

Cenamos en casa de mi abuela.
We have dinner at my grandmother's.

¿Me ayudas a poner el árbol?
Will you help me put the tree up?

Este regalo es para ti.
This present is for you.

¡Muchas gracias, me encanta!
Thank you so much, I love it!

¿Qué le pediste a los Reyes?
What did you ask the Kings for?

Vamos a cantar un villancico.
Let's sing a carol.

¡Qué bonito está todo! / ¡Qué lindo está todo!
Everything looks lovely!

Un abrazo muy fuerte.
A great big hug.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

El Gordo, the Spanish Christmas lottery, is drawn on 22 December and the winning numbers are sung out loud by the children of a Madrid school. Whole villages buy the same number together, so when it wins, everybody wins at once.

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08

¡A PRACTICAR!

ACTIVITIES

1 MATCH THEM UP

Write the letter of the English meaning next to each Spanish word or phrase.

1	la Nochebuena	☐	A	the Christmas carol
2	el villancico	☐	B	nougat
3	el belén	☐	C	the twelve grapes
4	el regalo	☐	D	Christmas Eve
5	los Reyes Magos	☐	E	the toast
6	el turrón	☐	F	the Three Kings
7	las doce uvas	☐	G	the parade
8	la cabalgata	☐	H	the nativity scene
9	el árbol de Navidad	☐	I	the Christmas tree
10	el brindis	☐	J	the present

2 ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

Read each sentence and circle V (true) or F (false).

1. La Nochebuena es el 24 de diciembre. **V** **F**
2. Los Reyes Magos llegan en septiembre. **V** **F**
3. En Argentina la Navidad es en verano. **V** **F**
4. El turrón es una sopa caliente. **V** **F**
5. Se comen doce uvas en Nochevieja. **V** **F**
6. El roscón de Reyes se come en agosto. **V** **F**

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3 LA CARTA DE CLARA

Complete Clara's letter to the Three Kings with the words from the box.

Reyes | carta | árbol | regalo | camellos | turrón | familia | enero

Queridos _____ Magos: os escribo esta _____ desde Granada. Ya hemos puesto el _____ y el belén en el salón. Este año pido un _____ muy pequeño: unos patines. Os dejo agua para los _____ y un poco de _____ encima de la mesa. El 6 de _____ me levanto temprano con toda mi _____. ¡Gracias!

4 SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

Write the word used in Argentina next to the one used in Spain.

- **el belén** → _____
- **la gamba** → _____
- **la tarta** → _____
- **el zumo** → _____
- **las chucherías** → _____
- **el móvil** → _____
- **el calcetín** → _____
- **bonito** → _____

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5 SOPA DE LETRAS

Find the 12 words. They go across → or down ↓.

H	N	N	R	C	F	P	N	T	I	E	U
N	O	T	I	O	M	N	H	E	C	F	V
A	N	O	C	H	E	B	U	E	N	A	A
V	E	H	T	U	R	R	O	N	H	A	S
I	R	C	E	N	A	U	B	E	L	E	N
D	F	I	J	A	E	O	T	M	V	R	U
A	L	E	S	V	B	P	T	N	N	E	N
D	N	C	A	N	T	A	R	D	R	G	V
N	B	G	C	A	M	E	L	L	O	A	E
E	S	T	R	E	L	L	A	C	G	L	L
P	A	R	B	O	L	F	D	L	V	O	A
B	D	A	U	E	T	D	M	V	A	C	G

NAVIDAD

NOCHEBUENA

REGALO

BELEN

TURRON

ESTRELLA

VELA

CAMELLO

UVAS

ARBOL

CENA

CANTAR

6 PUT IT IN ORDER

Unscramble each sentence and write it on the line.

1. **Navidad / ¡Feliz**

_____

2. **villancico / Vamos / cantar / un / a**

_____

3. **es / ti / regalo / para / Este**

_____

4. **a / doce / uvas / medianoche / Comemos**

_____

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7 TU NAVIDAD

Write four or five sentences about how you spend Christmas, or how you would like to spend it: who you are with, what you eat, what you do and what you'd ask the Three Kings for. Use at least six words from this resource.

Try: En Nochebuena cenamos... Ponemos el árbol... Mi familia... Este año pido... ¡Feliz Navidad!

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ANSWERS

1 · MATCH THEM UP

1–D, 2–A, 3–H, 4–J, 5–F, 6–B, 7–C, 8–G, 9–I, 10–E

2 · ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

1 V, 2 F, 3 V, 4 F, 5 V, 6 F

3 · LA CARTA DE CLARA

1. Reyes, 2. carta, 3. árbol, 4. regalo, 5. camellos, 6. turrón, 7. enero, 8. familia

4 · SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

el belén → el pesebre; la tarta → la torta; las chucherías → las golosinas; el calcetín → la media; la gamba → el camarón; el zumo → el jugo; el móvil → el celular; bonito → lindo

6 · PUT IT IN ORDER

¡Feliz Navidad! · Vamos a cantar un villancico. · Este regalo es para ti. · Comemos doce uvas a medianoche.

7 · TU NAVIDAD

Any answer that uses six words from this resource is perfect. Read it out loud at the table in December: that's exactly what it's for.

5 · SOPA DE LETRAS

H	N	N	R	C	F	P	N	T	I	E	U
N	O	T	I	O	M	N	H	E	C	F	V
A	N	O	C	H	E	B	U	E	N	A	A
V	E	H	T	U	R	R	O	N	H	A	S
I	R	C	E	N	A	U	B	E	L	E	N
D	F	I	J	A	E	O	T	M	V	R	U
A	L	E	S	V	B	P	T	N	N	E	N
D	N	C	A	N	T	A	R	D	R	G	V
N	B	G	C	A	M	E	L	L	O	A	E
E	S	T	R	E	L	L	A	C	G	L	L
P	A	R	B	O	L	F	D	L	V	O	A
B	D	A	U	E	T	D	M	V	A	C	G

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¡FELICES FIESTAS!

SEE YOU SOON

Now you can lay the table, sing badly, open a present and eat twelve grapes before the clock finishes. Whatever your December looks like, you can say it in Spanish.

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